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sian President Vladimir Putin at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Samarkand in 2022 that "today's era is not of war". Recently, Modi assured Ukraine's president Volodymyr Zelensky at the G7 summit in Hiroshima that India would do "whatever is possible" to find a solution to the conflict. In balancing its principles with its interests and maintaining a balance between the US and Russia—which is an important source of defence and energy—Indian foreign policy has been able to marry its concrete needs with its legacy of non-alignment. This blend of pragmatism and idealism is no hollow ad-hocism, though. If India has displayed a capacity in the past four years to pursue enlightened self-interest against a turbulent geopolitical canvas, its interventions have the common good of all nations in mind.

A grittier reality has confronted New Delhi along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), with the Indian army and the belligerent Chinese engaged in a protracted stand-off in Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh since the Galwan clash of 2020. Jaishankar has stated that bilateral ties with China had entered a "challenging and abnormal" phase and would not normalise unless all outstanding border issues are resolved. Multiple rounds of military as well as diplomatic dialogue with Beijing have brought disengagement and prevented further clashes, though with some tactical and territorial compromises. India's response has been to amp up its presence in the revived Quadrilateral Dialogue or Quad, where it partners the US, Japan and Australia. An important bulwark against Beijing, the Quad is key to containing its ambitions in the Indo-Pacific. Over the past four years, there have been three in-person Quad leaders' meeting; the latest one, on the sidelines of the G7 summit in May, reiterated the importance of a "free and open international rules-based order". The India-US strategic partnership has value that overrides domestic politics—Joe Biden, who took charge in January 2021, backs it as much as Donald Trump did.

Closer home, the 'Neighbourhood First' policy has remained a pillar of Indian diplomacy. In the past four years, India has delivered humanitarian aid to Afghanistan and, as a creditor, supported debt restructuring for crisis-hit Sri Lanka. Ties with Bangladesh, Maldives and Myanmar remain strong, while relations with Nepal are back on track. India's stand on ties with Pakistan remains unchanged—that any outstanding issue must be resolved in a terror-free environment. Further afield, Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) have been a key instrument to obtain better market access for India's exports. New Delhi has signed several such pacts—with Mauritius (2021), the UAE (2022) and the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement with Australia (2022). FTA negotiations with the UK and EU are in progress. Hosting the SCO summit in 2023 as its president will be a great opportunity to reach out to Central Asian nations.

Finally, India has assumed presidency of the G20 for 2023. As the leading voice of the Global South, it aims to incorporate the aspirations of smaller/developing nations into the G20 agenda. The finance ministers, central bank governors and foreign ministers have met. The heads of state summit in September will freeze-frame India's presence at the global high table. ■

"WE ARE ASKED WHOSE SIDE WE ARE ON. OUR ANSWER...IS STRAIGHT AND HONEST. INDIA IS ON THE SIDE OF PEACE AND WILL REMAIN FIRMLY THERE"

S. JAISHANKAR
at the UN General Assembly on September 24, 2022